

THE FIRST PULLBACK STUDY

Missed Bitcoin at \$57,735? Every rally of 40% or more since 2012, and every rally and pullback after the 2015, 2018 and 2022 bottoms, measured leg by leg.

How big the pullbacks were, how far they went, where the studies line up for 2026, and the line that separates a recovery from a bear market rally.



55 of 70

rallies of 40%+ since 2012
fell 20% or more

12 of 16

recovery pullbacks were
20% or more

-9%

the deepest dip of this rally
so far

Educational, not financial advice. Three recoveries is three recoveries. The legs are hand-measured on weekly wicks and checked against a second exchange, and the check is printed beside every one.



Bitcoin Jae
@bitcoin.daily

EVERY RALLY SINCE 2012

70 RALLIES, 70 PULLBACKS

RALLIES OF 40%+	HOW MANY	FELL 20%+	TYPICAL PULLBACK	RALLY GIVEN BACK	DAYS, TOP TO LOW	HELD ABOVE THE START
All rallies of 40%+	70	55/70 (79%)	-32%	80%	20	45/70 (64%)
Bear market rallies	12	12/12 (100%)	-44%	126%	47	4/12 (33%)
Bull markets	46	35/46 (76%)	-31%	76%	16	31/46 (67%)
The year after a bottom	12	8/12 (67%)	-24%	62%	36	10/12 (83%)

A rally runs from a swing low until a day trades 10% under the highest price before it. Pullback = the lowest wick within 90 days of the rally's top. Bear market rally = starts after a cycle top and before that bear's final low. Bitstamp daily, January 2012 to today.

Every rally of 40% or more since 2012 got a pullback. 55 of 70 fell 20% or more within three months of the top, the typical one 32%. Where the market was changed the size. In the year after a bottom the typical pullback was 24%. Inside bear markets all 12 rallies of 40% or more fell 20% or more, typically 44%, and most of them went on to a new low.

RALLY FROM	LOW	TOP	HIGH	RALLY	PULLBACK	PULLBACK LOW	HELD THE LOW
01 Dec 2013	\$796	04 Dec 2013	\$1,153	+45%	-67%	18 Dec 2013	no
07 Dec 2013	\$542	10 Dec 2013	\$990	+82%	-61%	18 Dec 2013	no
18 Dec 2013	\$382	19 Dec 2013	\$700	+83%	-43%	25 Feb 2014	yes
28 Dec 2013	\$682	06 Jan 2014	\$995	+46%	-60%	25 Feb 2014	no
25 Feb 2014	\$400	26 Feb 2014	\$610	+52%	-44%	11 Apr 2014	no
11 Apr 2014	\$340	16 Apr 2014	\$548	+61%	-23%	06 May 2014	yes
06 May 2014	\$420	01 Jun 2014	\$683	+63%	-35%	18 Aug 2014	yes
05 Oct 2014	\$275	09 Oct 2014	\$396	+44%	-36%	04 Jan 2015	no
17 Jan 2018	\$9,222	20 Jan 2018	\$13,052	+42%	-55%	06 Feb 2018	no
06 Feb 2018	\$5,921	07 Feb 2018	\$8,649	+46%	-26%	01 Apr 2018	yes
11 Feb 2018	\$7,820	20 Feb 2018	\$11,780	+51%	-45%	01 Apr 2018	no
06 Apr 2018	\$6,510	24 Apr 2018	\$9,737	+50%	-41%	29 Jun 2018	no

Every bear market rally of 40%+ since 2012. The 2022 bear had none this big. 2026's only one so far is the rally from 1 July.

THE LINE, AND WHY IT MATTERED

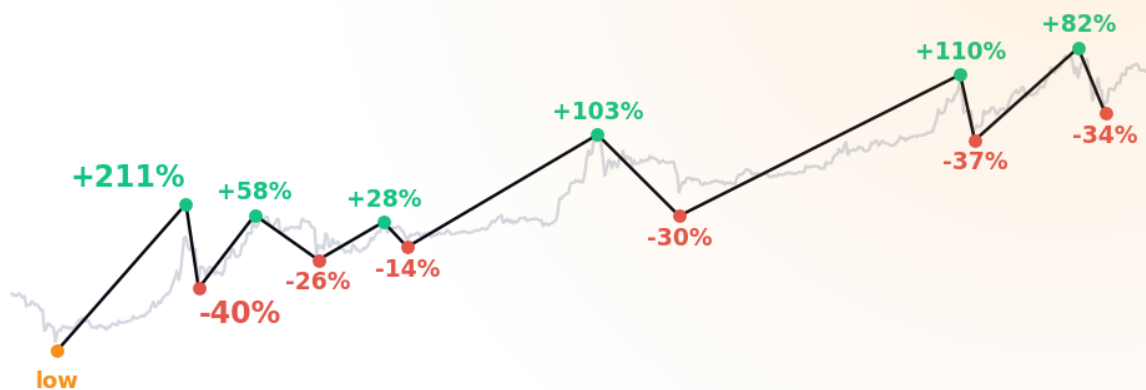


A bear market is a staircase down. Each rally tops out below the one before it, \$126,272 in October 2025, \$97,939 in January, \$82,833 in May. While that holds, every rally is a lower high and the structure is a bear. The staircase only ends when price gets back above the last step.

On 21 September 2026, in the 4am Eastern hour, Bitcoin went through \$82,833 on roughly ten times normal volume and ran to \$87,374, its highest since January. About \$648 million of short positions were liquidated on the way. The day closed at \$86,587, and on 27 September the week closed at \$84,457, the first weekly close above \$82,833 since January.

So the useful question is not whether the bottom is in. It is what a recovery actually looks like if it is. The next three pages measure every leg of the last three.

AFTER THE 2015 BOTTOM



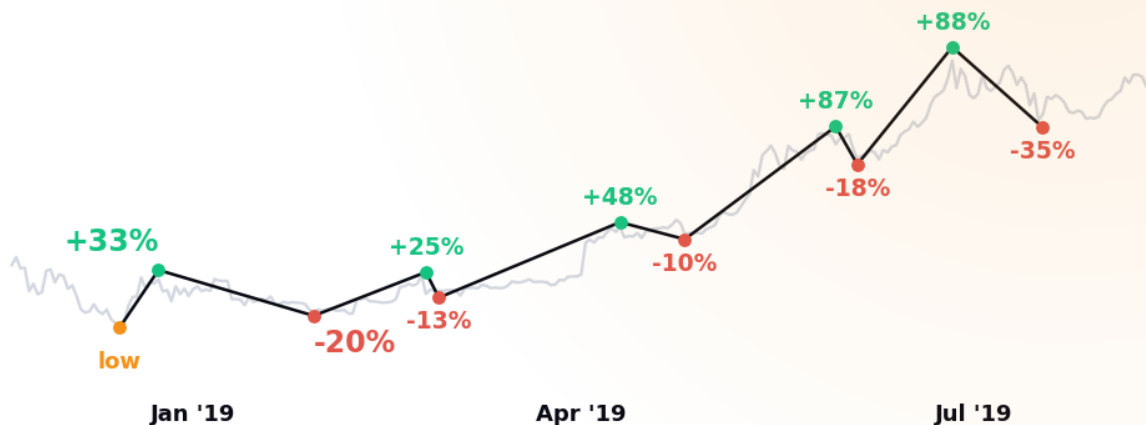
Aug '15 Nov '15 Feb '16 May '16 Aug '16 Nov '16 Feb '17 May '17
After the 2015 bottom. Every rally and pullback of the recovery, measured on weekly wicks. Log scale.

#	LEG	FROM	TO	START	END	MEASURED	BITSTAMP	WEEKS
1	rally	25 Aug 2015	04 Nov 2015	\$198	\$502	+211%	+153%	10
2	pullback	04 Nov 2015	11 Nov 2015	\$502	\$294	-40%	-41%	1
3	rally	11 Nov 2015	12 Dec 2015	\$294	\$468	+58%	+59%	4
4	pullback	12 Dec 2015	16 Jan 2016	\$468	\$352	-26%	-25%	5
5	rally	16 Jan 2016	21 Feb 2016	\$352	\$448	+28%	+27%	5
6	pullback	21 Feb 2016	05 Mar 2016	\$448	\$382	-14%	-15%	2
7	rally	05 Mar 2016	18 Jun 2016	\$382	\$779	+103%	+104%	15
8	pullback	18 Jun 2016	02 Aug 2016	\$779	\$465	-30%	-40%	6
9	rally	02 Aug 2016	04 Jan 2017	\$465	\$1,140	+110%	+145%	22
10	pullback	04 Jan 2017	12 Jan 2017	\$1,140	\$751	-37%	-34%	1
11	rally	12 Jan 2017	10 Mar 2017	\$751	\$1,350	+82%	+80%	8
12	pullback	10 Mar 2017	25 Mar 2017	\$1,350	\$891	-34%	-34%	2

Measured = weekly wicks on the chart the leg was drawn on. Bitstamp = the same leg on Bitstamp daily wicks, as a check. 2015 was drawn on Bitfinex, whose August 2015 and August 2016 wicks differ from Bitstamp's.

The first rally tripled price in ten weeks. Then it gave back 40% in a single week. Six pullbacks on the way up, five of them 20% or more, and the recovery still carried price to almost 7 times its low on Bitstamp.

AFTER THE 2018 BOTTOM



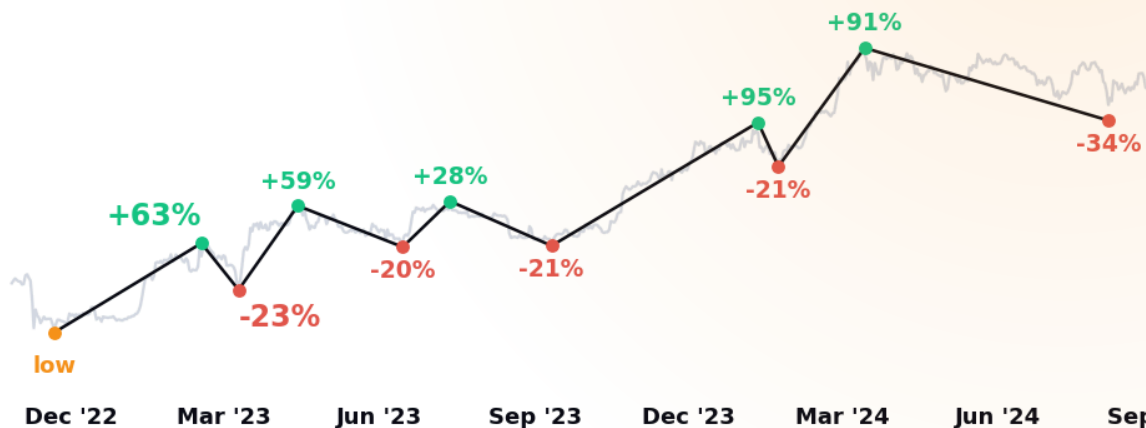
After the 2018 bottom. Every rally and pullback of the recovery, measured on weekly wicks. Log scale.

#	LEG	FROM	TO	START	END	MEASURED	BITSTAMP	WEEKS
1	rally	15 Dec 2018	24 Dec 2018	\$3,122	\$4,237	+33%	+36%	1
2	pullback	24 Dec 2018	29 Jan 2019	\$4,237	\$3,322	-20%	-22%	5
3	rally	29 Jan 2019	24 Feb 2019	\$3,322	\$4,190	+25%	+26%	4
4	pullback	24 Feb 2019	27 Feb 2019	\$4,190	\$3,658	-13%	-13%	1
5	rally	27 Feb 2019	10 Apr 2019	\$3,658	\$5,466	+48%	+49%	6
6	pullback	10 Apr 2019	25 Apr 2019	\$5,466	\$4,991	-10%	-9%	2
7	rally	25 Apr 2019	30 May 2019	\$4,991	\$9,097	+87%	+82%	5
8	pullback	30 May 2019	04 Jun 2019	\$9,097	\$7,433	-18%	-18%	1
9	rally	04 Jun 2019	26 Jun 2019	\$7,433	\$13,880	+88%	+87%	3
10	pullback	26 Jun 2019	17 Jul 2019	\$13,880	\$9,050	-35%	-35%	3

Measured = weekly wicks on the chart the leg was drawn on. Bitstamp = the same leg on Bitstamp daily wicks, as a check.

The first rally was the smallest of the three, +33% in nine days. The first pullback took five weeks, gave back 20% and stopped 6% above the low. It looked exactly like a failed rally. Price then quadrupled in five months. This recovery never reached a new all-time high before the 2020 crash, so its chart ends at the June 2019 peak and the 35% drop that followed.

RECOVERY THREE AFTER THE 2022 BOTTOM



After the 2022 bottom. Every rally and pullback of the recovery, measured on weekly wicks. Log scale.

#	LEG	FROM	TO	START	END	MEASURED	BITSTAMP	WEEKS
1	rally	21 Nov 2022	16 Feb 2023	\$15,479	\$25,270	+63%	+63%	12
2	pullback	16 Feb 2023	10 Mar 2023	\$25,270	\$19,569	-23%	-23%	3
3	rally	10 Mar 2023	14 Apr 2023	\$19,569	\$31,035	+59%	+59%	5
4	pullback	14 Apr 2023	15 Jun 2023	\$31,035	\$24,756	-20%	-20%	9
5	rally	15 Jun 2023	13 Jul 2023	\$24,756	\$31,818	+28%	+29%	4
6	pullback	13 Jul 2023	11 Sep 2023	\$31,818	\$24,920	-21%	-22%	9
7	rally	11 Sep 2023	11 Jan 2024	\$24,920	\$49,048	+95%	+97%	17
8	pullback	11 Jan 2024	23 Jan 2024	\$49,048	\$38,505	-21%	-21%	2
9	rally	23 Jan 2024	14 Mar 2024	\$38,505	\$73,794	+91%	+92%	7
10	pullback	14 Mar 2024	05 Aug 2024	\$73,794	\$49,577	-34%	-33%	21

Measured = weekly wicks on the chart the leg was drawn on. Bitstamp = the same leg on Bitstamp daily wicks, as a check.

The cleanest of the three. +63%, then -23%, and then every single pullback on the way up was 20% or more, five of five. Price still went up almost five times. A 20% drop was not a sign the recovery had failed. It was the rhythm of it.

THE FIRST PULLBACK IS THE ONE THAT MATTERS

BOTTOM	FIRST RALLY	TOOK	FIRST PULLBACK	TOOK	PULLBACK LOW VS THE BOTTOM	PULLBACKS OF 20%+
2015	+211%	10w	-40%	1w	+48%	5 of 6
2018	+33%	1w	-20%	5w	+6%	2 of 5
2022	+63%	12w	-23%	3w	+26%	5 of 5
2026	+51.3% so far	12w	not yet			

All three first pullbacks held above the bottom. That hold is what made it the bottom. The 2026 row counts 12 weeks to the 21 September high.

Across the three recoveries there were 16 rallies and 16 pullbacks. The typical rally was +73% and the smallest +25%. The typical pullback was -22%, the shallowest -10%, the deepest -40%. 12 of 16 pullbacks were 20% or more and 5 were 30% or more. A typical pullback gave back 63% of the rally before it. Each of the three charts ends with a drop of about a third, -34%, -35% and -34%.

After every one of the three bottoms the very first rally got sold, by 40%, 20% and 23%. None of those first rallies told you the bottom was in. A first rally off a low looks the same in a recovery and in a bear market rally. What separated them was the pullback. In all three recoveries it stopped above the low, and in the bear market rallies it did not.

THE FINDING

The first rally never told you. The first pullback did.

FOUR MORE STUDIES

SAME ANSWER, FOUR WAYS

CALM RUN	DAYS WITHOUT A 10% PULLBACK	RALLY TO ITS TOP	THE PULLBACK THAT ENDED IT	6 MONTHS LATER
Aug 2016	156	+145%	-34%	+159%
Mar 2016	108	+104%	-40%	+20%
Sep 2023	91	+79%	-10%	+69%
Oct 2012	91	+98%	-16%	+414%
Aug 2015	72	+103%	-13%	+9%
Oct 2024	70	+84%	-18%	+8%
Sep 2020	65	+60%	-10%	+297%
Apr 2012	60	+39%	-10%	+103%
Jun 2025	60	+27%	-14%	-40%

Every run of 60 days or more from a low without a 10% pullback, since 2012 (The Up Only Study). 2026's run is 100 days and counting, the 3rd longest.

Calm runs. All 9 ended with a pullback of 10% to 40%, and 6 months after each one ended price was higher in 8 of 9. The pullback came, and the run did not die.

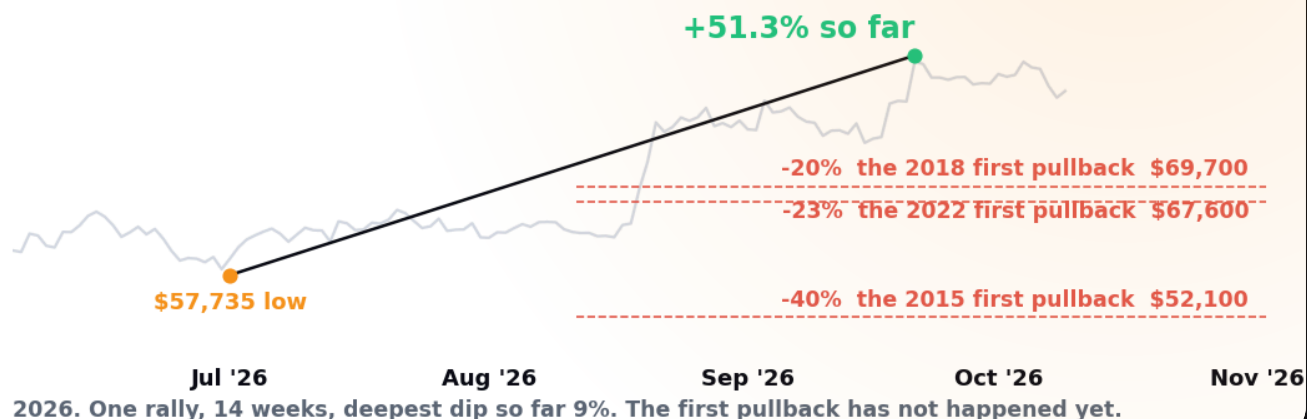
Big quarters. Bitcoin had 20 quarters of +30% or more since 2012. Inside every next quarter price fell 20% or more from the high, 20 of 20. The smallest drop was 20% and the typical one 41% (The Quarter Study). Q3 2026 was +43%.

Big green candles. Inside every past bear market, all 43 massive green daily candles were filled, price came back to where they opened (The Big Candle Study). Four from this rally are still open, opened at \$76,355 (18 September), \$73,000 (21 August), \$69,298 (20 August) and \$64,686 (19 August).

October. From the \$84,000 reference on 1 October, the month odds published that day were 46% for a 10% correction at some point in October and 23% for a 20% one (The October 2026 Playbook).

THE LIVE CASE

2026, ONE RALLY AND NO PULLBACK YET



IF THE FIRST PULLBACK MATCHES	SIZE	FROM THE \$87,374 HIGH	AGAINST THE \$57,735 LOW
2018	-20%	\$69,700	holds above
2022	-23%	\$67,600	holds above
2015	-40%	\$52,100	breaks below

Levels move up if the rally makes a higher high first. They are analogs, not targets.

From the 1 July low at \$57,735 Bitcoin ran 51.3% to \$87,374 on 21 September, and 100 days in, the deepest dip inside the rally is 9%. By the record of the last three recoveries the first real pullback has not happened yet. A 2018 or 2022 sized one from the high lands at \$69,700 to \$67,600. A 2015 sized one lands under the low, which would make this rally one more lower high.

THE READ

Every rally got its pullback. Plan the buy for it, and watch where it stops.

THE LEVEL MAP

WHERE THE STUDIES LINE UP

PRICE	WHAT IT IS	RECORD
\$87,374	the 21 September high, the top of this rally so far	
\$78,600	a 10% pullback	16 of 16 recovery pullbacks got here
\$76,355	the 18 September big green candle opened here	unfilled
\$73,000	the 21 August big green candle opened here	unfilled
\$69,900	a 20% pullback	12 of 16
\$69,700	2018's first pullback, -20%	held above its low
\$69,298	the 20 August big green candle opened here	unfilled
\$68,800	a typical recovery pullback, 63% of the rally given back	median of 16
\$67,600	2022's first pullback, -23%	held above its low
\$64,686	the 19 August big green candle opened here	unfilled
\$61,200	a 30% pullback	5 of 16
\$57,735	the 1 July low, the line	below it, the rally was a bear market rally
\$52,100	2015's first pullback, -40%	a new low from here
\$49,300	a typical bear market rally pullback, -44%	a new low from here

Pullback levels are measured from the 21 September high of \$87,374 and move up if Bitcoin makes a higher high first. Candle opens are fixed prices.

Four different studies point at the same few thousand dollars. 2022's first pullback lands at \$67,600, a typical recovery pullback at \$68,800, the 20 August candle opened at \$69,298 and a 20% pullback is \$69,900. A pullback that holds above \$57,735 is what every real recovery did. One that breaks it is what every bear market rally did.

THE MAP

The pullback zone, \$67,600 to \$69,900. The line, \$57,735.

THE TRAP TEST

ALL 19 GRADED BREAKS OF THE LAST LOWER HIGH

BREAK	LEVEL	DAYS FROM LOW	UP FROM LOW	+30D	+90D	+180D	WORST DIP 90D	
20 Dec 2011	\$4	25	+82%	+37%	+6%	+36%	-16%	
18 Apr 2012	\$5	145	+106%	-2%	+66%	+126%	-7%	
19 Aug 2013	\$100	129	+129%	+23%	+364%	+538%	-17%	
25 May 2014	\$548	44	+69%	-0%	-13%	-39%	-23%	TRAP
12 Nov 2014	\$418	38	+55%	-17%	-48%	-43%	-64%	TRAP
02 Mar 2015	\$268	47	+80%	-10%	-17%	-16%	-24%	
16 Jun 2015	\$247	153	+64%	+11%	-8%	+73%	-21%	
06 Oct 2015	\$246	265	+62%	+56%	+76%	+70%	-2%	
15 Apr 2016	\$428	457	+182%	+7%	+53%	+48%	-1%	
11 Oct 2016	\$629	636	+319%	+12%	+40%	+89%	-2%	
23 Feb 2019	\$4,112	70	+32%	-5%	+94%	+146%	-11%	
26 Oct 2019	\$8,820	315	+196%	-23%	-9%	-19%	-31%	
23 Apr 2020	\$7,469	495	+140%	+23%	+27%	+59%	-1%	
10 Oct 2020	\$11,183	665	+262%	+36%	+260%	+414%	-1%	
26 Oct 2022	\$20,469	130	+18%	-21%	+9%	+32%	-25%	TRAP
12 Jan 2023	\$18,373	52	+22%	+16%	+59%	+62%	-1%	
21 Jun 2023	\$28,452	212	+94%	-0%	-9%	+42%	-17%	
23 Oct 2023	\$30,210	336	+114%	+13%	+26%	+96%	-1%	
17 Apr 2026	\$76,013	70	+29%	+0%	-17%		-25%	TRAP
19 Aug 2026	\$66,921	49	+20%	+17%			-1%	

Bitstamp daily. Bear state = 35%+ under the all-time high. Last lower high on 14-day wick pivots. Break = first daily close above it. TRAP = a new bear-market low followed. The August 2026 row is too recent to grade and is not in the 19.

Every time Bitcoin closed above its last lower high inside a bear market, 19 graded cases. After 15 of them no new low ever followed. Four were traps. Split by how early the break came and the picture changes. Breaks within 90 days of the low, 7 cases, 3 traps, and 90 days later a median -13%. Later breaks, 12 cases, 1 trap, +34%. The September 2026 break came on day 82, and this bear already produced one trap, the 17 April close above \$76,013.

WHAT THIS STUDY DOES NOT SAY

Three recoveries. Every statistic on the legs comes from three charts. They describe what recoveries have looked like, not what this one must do.

The legs are hand-measured. Where a leg starts and ends is a judgement. That is why every leg is printed with its dates, its prices and a second-exchange check, so you can disagree with any of them.

The 70 rallies mix every kind of market. They include the wild 2013 moves and the bear market rallies of 2014 and 2018, and the answer changes a lot by market, which is why the table splits them.

The recoveries are known in hindsight. The three bottoms are only bottoms because the first pullback held. In real time a first rally off a low and a bear market rally are the same object, which is the entire point of the first-pullback table.

The levels move. Every pullback level here is measured from \$87,374. If Bitcoin runs higher first, the pullback starts higher and every level moves up with it. The candle opens and the July low do not move.

Data pinned 9 October 2026. Legs measured on weekly wicks (2015 Bitfinex, 2018 and 2022 Binance), checked on Bitstamp BTC/USD daily wicks. Scripts: Legs/legs_charts.py, RallyPullback/rp_study.py, UpOnly/uo_study2.py, Quarters/q_study.py, Engulfing/eg_study.py, LowerHigh/lh_study.py. This is education, not financial advice.

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